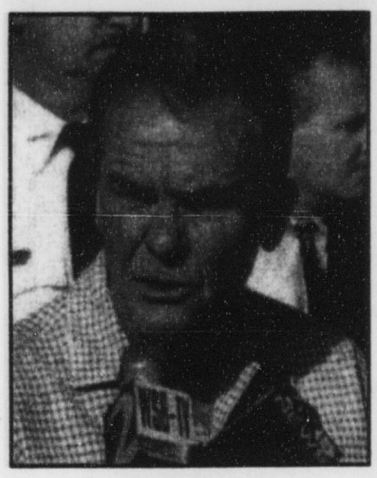
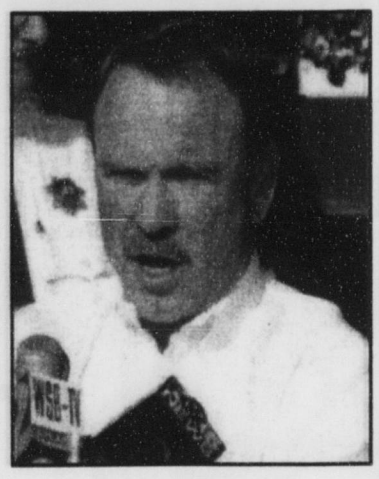
The Forsyth County News

Opinion

This is a page of opinions — ours, yours and others. Signed columns and cartoons are the opinions of the writers and artists and may not reflect our views.



Bob Davis



Tommy Bagwell

Frady reward offers glimmer of hope for new information

The death of Levi Frady remains an injustice that haunts the Forsyth County community. Thanks to the generosity of two local businessmen, there is now a better chance of solving one of the county's most horrific mysteries.



Frady

Last week, Tommy Bagwell, owner of American Proteins, and automobile dealer Bob Davis each agreed to add $50,000 to the reward being offered for information about the Levi Frady murder.

We can only hope that the addition of $100,000 to the existing reward fund, bringing the total to approximately $125,000, will provide the incentive necessary to unveil new clues in the murder.

A North Forsyth Middle School student, 11-year-old Levi disappeared while riding his bicycle Oct. 22, 1997. Deer hunters found his body the next day. The youngster had been shot to death.

Investigators from Dawson and Forsyth counties, as well as the GBI, have worked diligently to find the killer.

Forsyth County Sheriff Denny Hendrix recently formed a new task force to investigate Levi's death, reviving interest in the case and resulting in the posting of the increased reward.

The newly promised reward money will be added to that already pledged by many others, including the governor's office, Forsyth County Commission, Forsyth Sheriff's Department, Dawson County officials and community leaders, and several private individuals.

The $100,000 added to the reward fund last week serves as a strong reminder that the case remains near to the hearts of many in Forsyth County and, at the same time, demonstrates the generosity and community spirit of the two individuals who have promised to make the funds available.

For that they are to be commended.

At the press conference announcing the new reward money, Bagwell noted that he has had a lengthy relationship with Frady family members.

"I have a long history with the family. I hope this helps," Bagwell said.

Davis said he hoped his donation "helps bring justice to Levi Frady."

So do we all.

Letter policy

The *Forsyth County News* welcomes your opinions on issues of public concern. Letters must be signed and include full address and a daytime and evening phone number for verification. Names and hometowns of letter writers will be included for publication without exception. Telephone numbers will not be published.

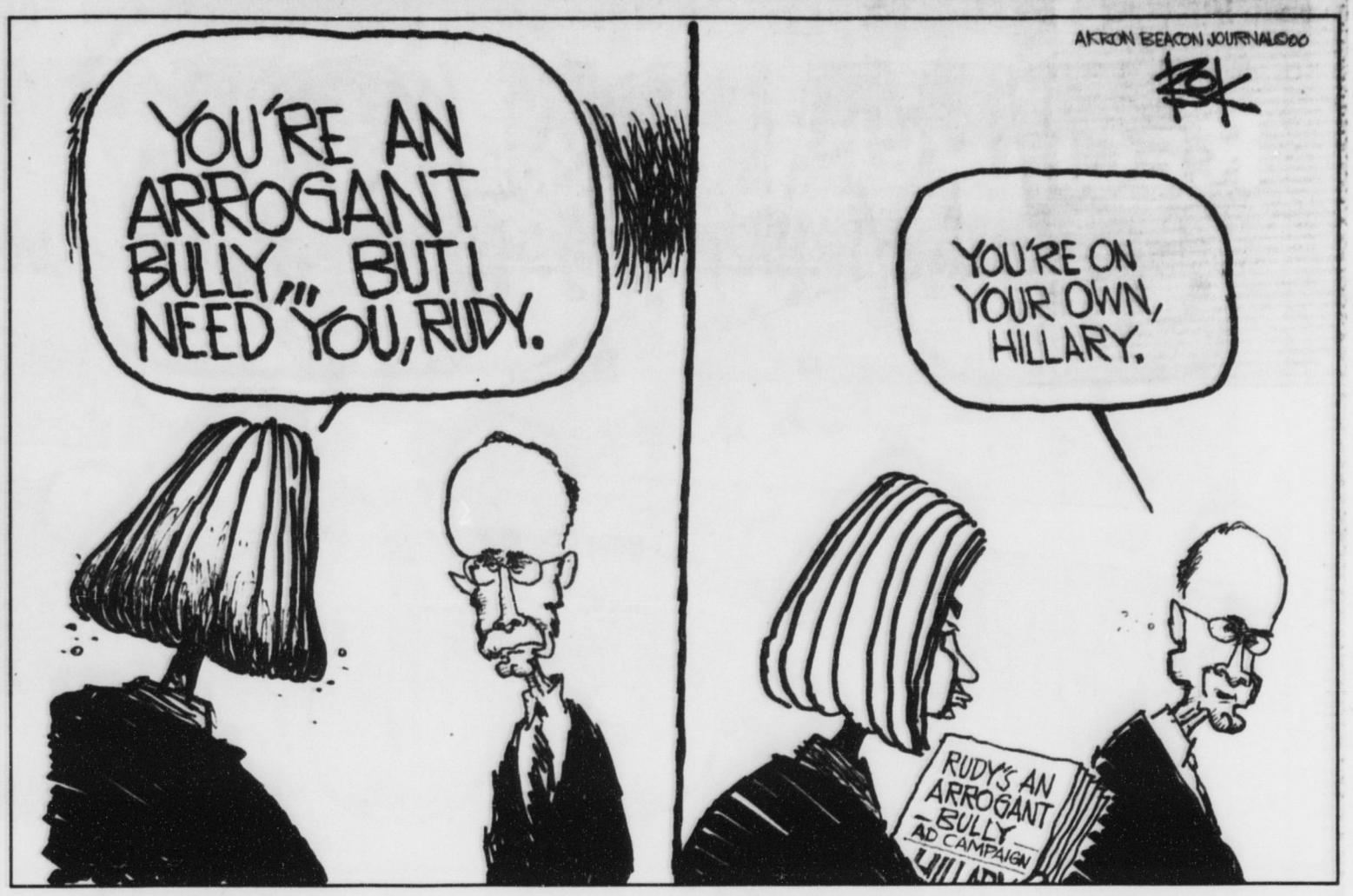
Letters should be limited to 350 words and may be edited or condensed. The same writer or group may only submit one letter per month for consideration.

Letters must be submitted by noon Wednesday for Sunday publication. We do not publish poetry or blanket letters and generally do not publish letters concerning consumer complaints. Unsigned or incorrectly identified letters will be withheld.

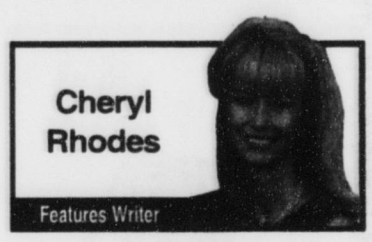
Mail letters to the *Forsyth County News*, P.O. Box 210, Cumming, GA 30028, hand deliver to 302 Old Buford Road, fax to (770) 889-6017 or email to editor@forsythnews.com.



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Asbestos in crayons not a colorful dilemma



Cheryl Rhodes
Features Writer

It was a rainy day and, therefore, a crafts day. I had all the stand-bys gathered from my official Stay-At-Home-Mom closet and wholesome activities were being systematically and dutifully enjoyed.

Distracted by my industrious tasks of organization, I didn't notice my wee one had begun a project all her own.

When she grinned at me, Savannah's toothy smile boasted flecks of purple and cheery remnants of blizzard blue.

At 13 months, she was electrified not just by the sight of a pile of crayons waiting to be scribbled across any willing canvas — aka "wall" — but also by their waxy, pungent flavor and heady scent.

It could have been much, much — 92 more muches — worse.

I, after all, am a happenin' Mom and so my kids have long had Crayola's 96-Crayons-with-Built-In-Sharpener box o' fun ever at the ready.

Have blank paper, good intentions and abundant forgiveness, will travel.

All the way to the coal mines, it seems.

Turns out tests conducted by a Seattle newspaper have revealed three major brands of crayons — yes, including our beloved Crayola — contain asbestos.

According to the Post-Intelligencer, four domestic and four overseas brands were examined by government-certified laboratories in a continuing investigation of asbestos hazards in consumer products and the difficulties in regulating them. Three — Crayola, Prang and Rose Art — repeatedly turned up the lethal fibers.

In fact, a staggering 80 percent of the 40 crayons tested from the brands with asbestos yielded contamination above the trace — no pun intended — level. Only fibers of the length, size-ratio and type that government and medical experts have stated are known to cause cancer were reported.

Thinking it's a good thing the contamination trend was confined to Seattle?

No such luck.

It was not a regional anomaly, as the level of the scary stuff was consistent in those crayons also purchased in California, Massachusetts, Florida and Texas.

But wait.

Ever noticed that "Certified Non-Toxic" comfort banner stretching across the top of most crayon boxes?

Surely there's protection in that.

Wishful thinking. Seems they were looking out for a whole lotta bugaboos but no one was testing for asbestos.

Unfortunate, since talc is a key ingredient in the colorful fun sticks and likely facilitates the asbestos presence.

You can imagine the brouhaha that is erupting.

Industry officials are pleading ignorance and scrambling to check out the legitimacy of the claims. Testing specialists are insisting the find is faulty. And parents and pediatricians are coming up with some colorful words of outrage all their own.

The dangers, after all, of asbestos are no secret. Tens of thousands have died of asbestos-caused diseases.

Though the Environmental Protection Agency banned products containing asbestos in 1989, a federal appeals court later threw out the ban after a legal challenge by the asbestos industries.

Its presence in crayons presents a frightening issue. While the amounts of asbestos discovered in the popular kids' pastime were far lower than exposures received by most miners and construction workers who have suffered, studies show that children are far more susceptible to toxins and carcinogens than adults.

Crayola alone makes 12 million crayons a day and estimates each kid wears down an average of 723 by age 10.

"Everyone who has a child knows that everything goes into their mouth," Dr. Michael Harbut, director of the Center for Occupational and Environmental Medicine in Detroit, told P-I reporters. "The old shoe box, or whatever a child uses to keep their old crayons, has a layer of bits of wax and crayon shavings in the bottom.

"This gets all over their hands and into their nose and mouth," said Harbut. "If there's asbestos in that wax, you've got the potential for real health hazards."

Great.

So now worrying about stick-figure artwork on freshly repainted, glistening white walls is no longer enough.

Sure, I'm quite certain the powers that be among the crayon giants will quickly rectify this potentially volatile snafu.

Already they are parading the spokespersons and promises that safety and consumer trust is paramount.

But each time Savannah lifts a slender Orchid crayon from its crowded nest inside that box, I'm going to think of how it scored a 2.86 percent on the asbestos scale. Or when Corey rushes to retrieve an orange crayon from the Rose Art collection he received for his birthday, its 1.20 percent grade will haunt me.

And I will wonder.

No one told me when I left the hospital with my newly born that my official Stay-At-Home-Mom closet should also include a mask and body armor for my nugget's future artistic endeavors.

I think for now our art shelf will remain temporarily bare.

Color me cautious; color me blue.

But color my kids healthy.

